

DOWNWARD-FACING DOG

Adho mukha svanasana

Also known as “Downward dog,” this is a common pose in modern yoga classes, particularly as an integral part of sun salutations or flow sequences. This arm balance is a forward fold and partial inversion, stretching the back of your legs and strengthening your shoulders.

THE BIG PICTURE

In this pose, the back of your body—including your buttocks, thighs, and calf muscles—is stretching. Your shoulders are strengthening as you press into the floor.

Torso

Your **transversus abdominis** stabilizes your spine and core. Your **spinal extensors** engage while your spine remains neutral or in slight extension. Your **middle** and **lower trapezius** engage to stabilize and slightly depress your scapulae. Your **latissimus dorsi** stretches.

